Where are the group member names (showing the varied perspectives of the members: India, Japan, Korea) and the data is Spring 2026!

HARVARD UNIVERSITY · DATA VISUALIZATION · SPRING 2025

Built by *Immigrants,* Threatened by Policy

Does the narrative stick? Specif target audience (policy makers, immigrants, general public, etc.)

Visualizing the impact of immigrant entrepreneurs on the U.S. innovation economy — and what we stand to lose.

◆ Interactive Data Story — 8 min read

The focus of the narrative is solely on “immigrants in Tech” but look if there is a need to include a “zoomed-out” perspective first that includes economic impact/tax revenue that is generated by the non-tech and typical immigrants (to show a fuller picture first). A holistic view of the economic impact to narratve the idea that the entire immigrant body (and not just the immigrants in tech) is not getting the full benefits for their contributions.

ACT I

How many services did you use today that were founded by immigrants?

Google. YouTube. Zoom. Tesla. WhatsApp. Stripe. The products you rely on every day were built by people who came to America from somewhere else. Hover over each to learn more.

🔍 **Google**
🎬 **YouTube**
📹 **Zoom**
⚡ **Tesla**
💬 **WhatsApp**
💳 **Stripe**
🖥 **NVIDIA**
🍔 **DoorDash**
🛒 **eBay**
🛵 **Instacart**
💊 **Pfizer**
💉 **Moderna**

ACT II

An Undeniable Scale

Immigrants are ~14% of the U.S. population. Their outsized impact on innovation is not anecdotal — it's structural.

46.2%
of Fortune 500 companies founded by immigrants or their children
American Immigration Council, 2025

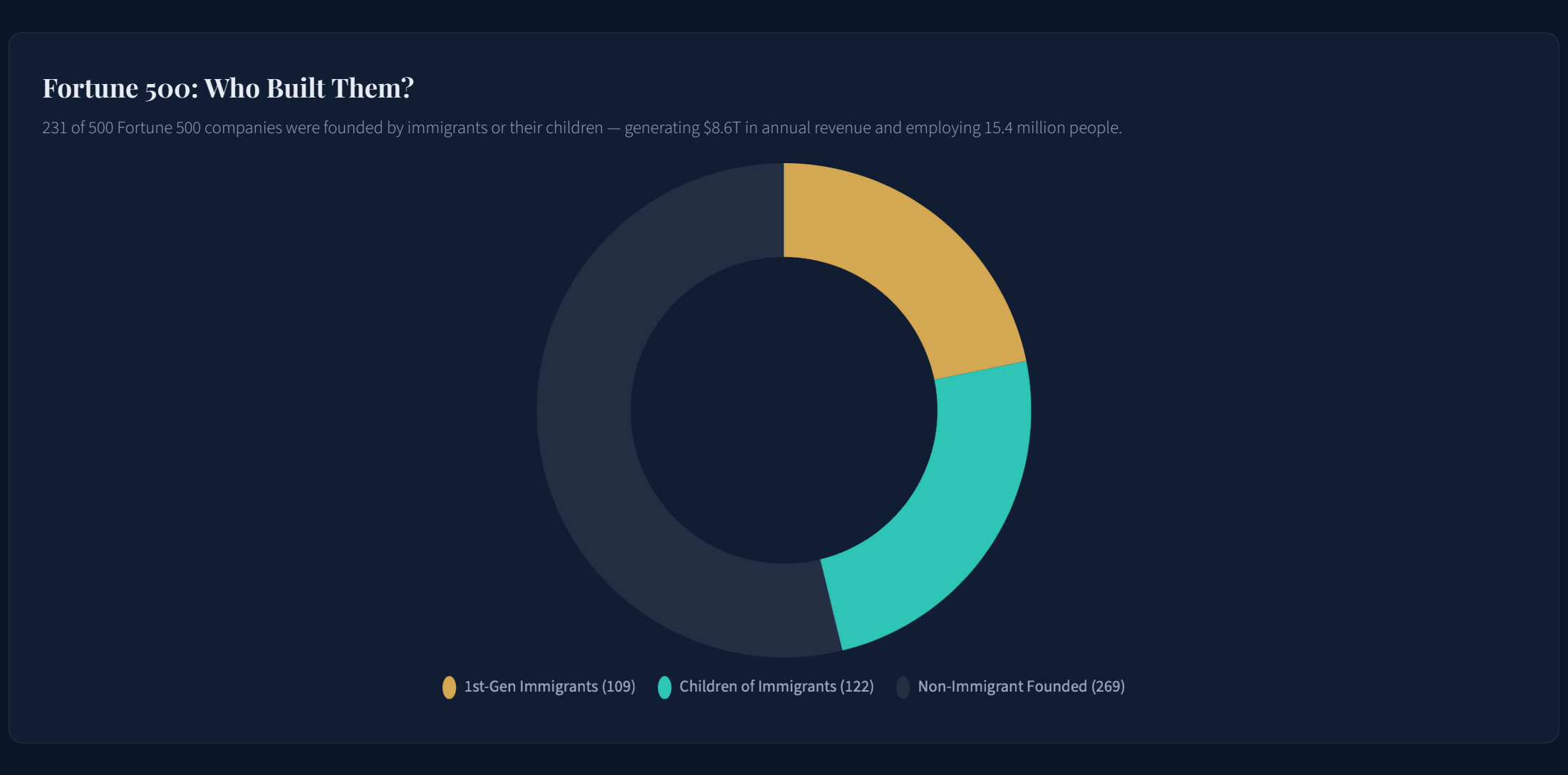
55%
of U.S. unicorn startups have an immigrant founder
NFAP, 2022

$8.6T
annual revenue from immigrant-founded Fortune 500 firms
World's 3rd-largest economy equivalent

36%
of all U.S. patent innovation involves immigrant inventors
NBER Working Paper 30797, 2023

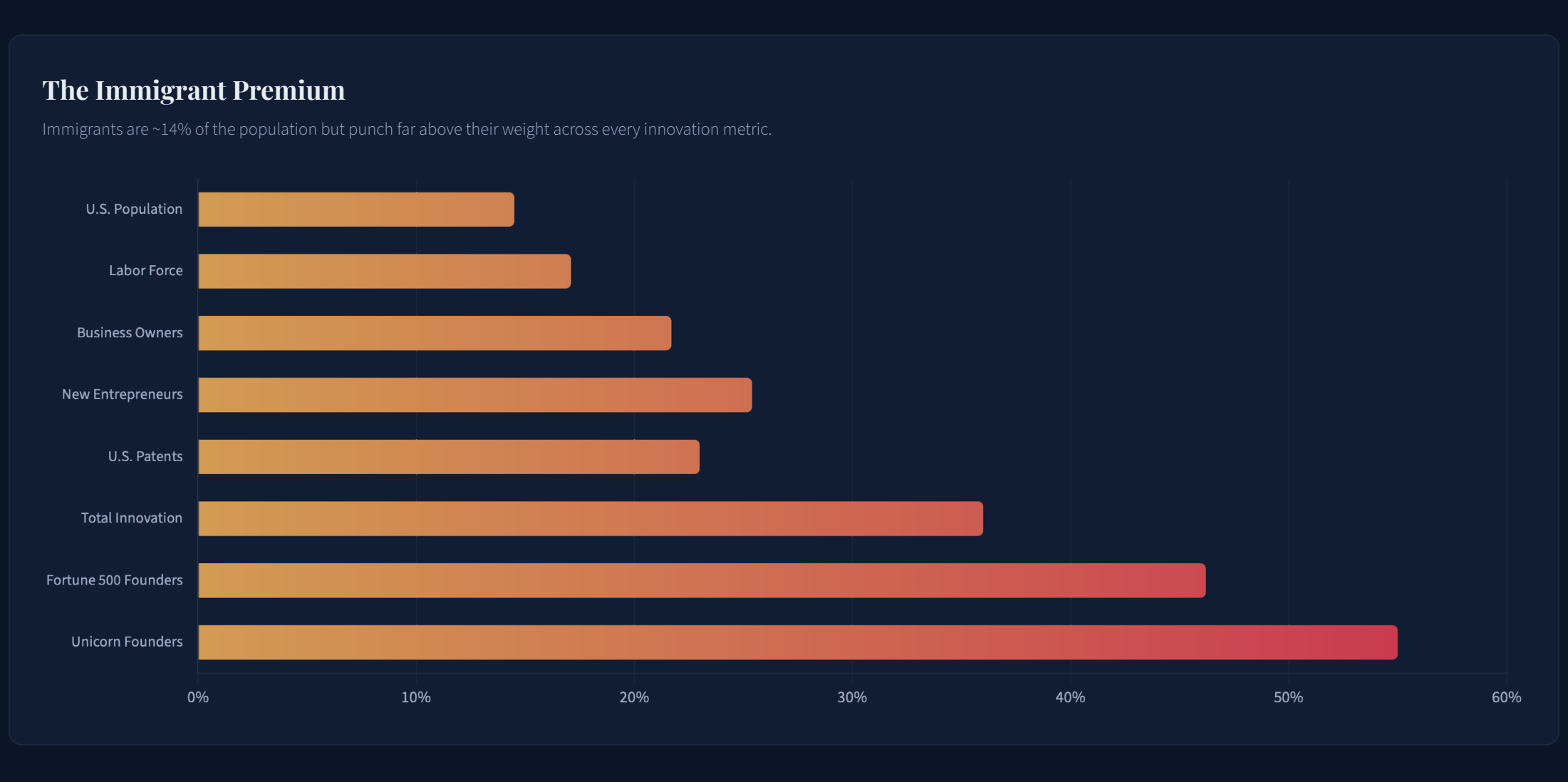
Fortune 500: Who Built Them?

231 of 500 Fortune 500 companies were founded by immigrants or their children — generating $8.6T in annual revenue and employing 15.4 million people.



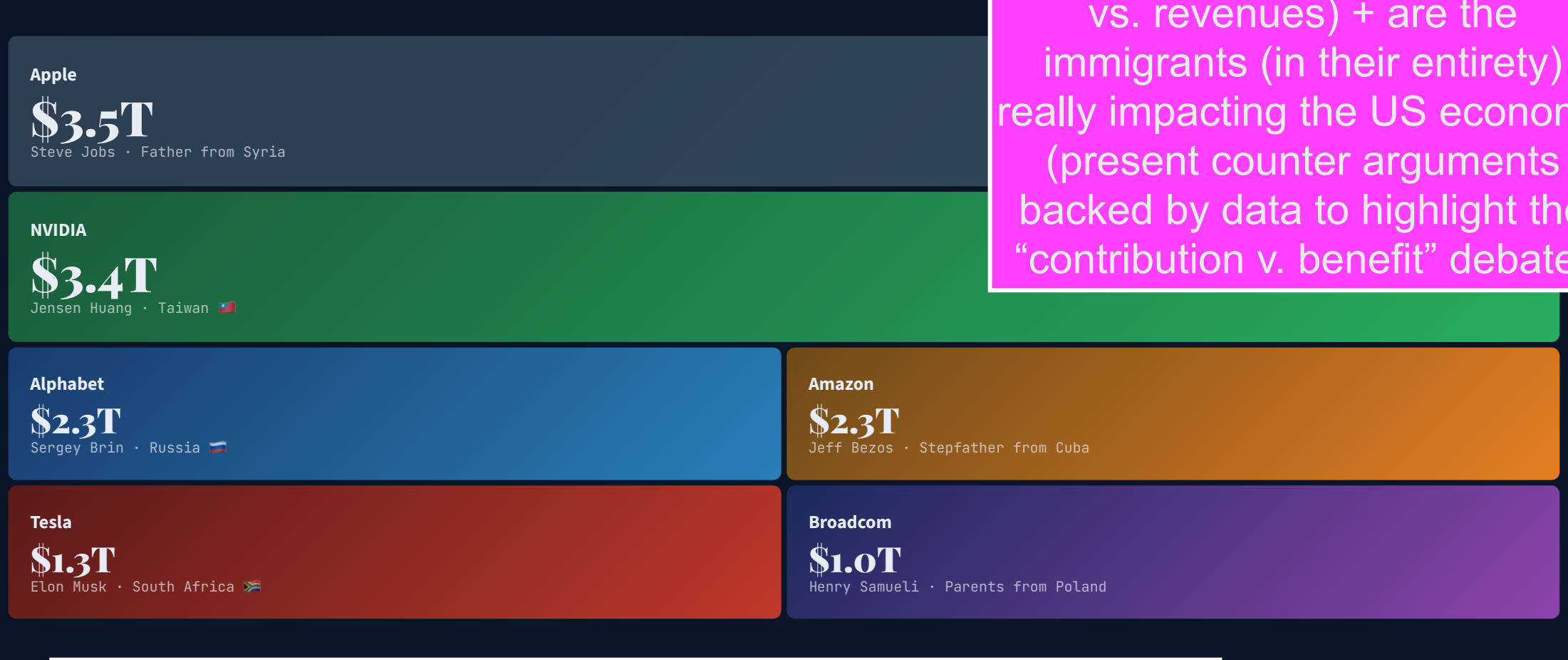
The Immigrant Premium

Immigrants are ~14% of the population but punch far above their weight across every innovation metric.



Market Cap: $13.8 Trillion

The top 6 immigrant-connected companies represent ~23% of the entire S&P 500.



Economic Impact: tax (evasions vs. revenues) + are the immigrants (in their entirety) really impacting the US economy (present counter arguments backed by data to highlight the “contribution v. benefit” debate)

What about including SMBs and mid-sized businesses (by immigrants) so that there is a more holistic take on the economic impact (and the impact can actually be amplified compared to when including only the biggest companies)

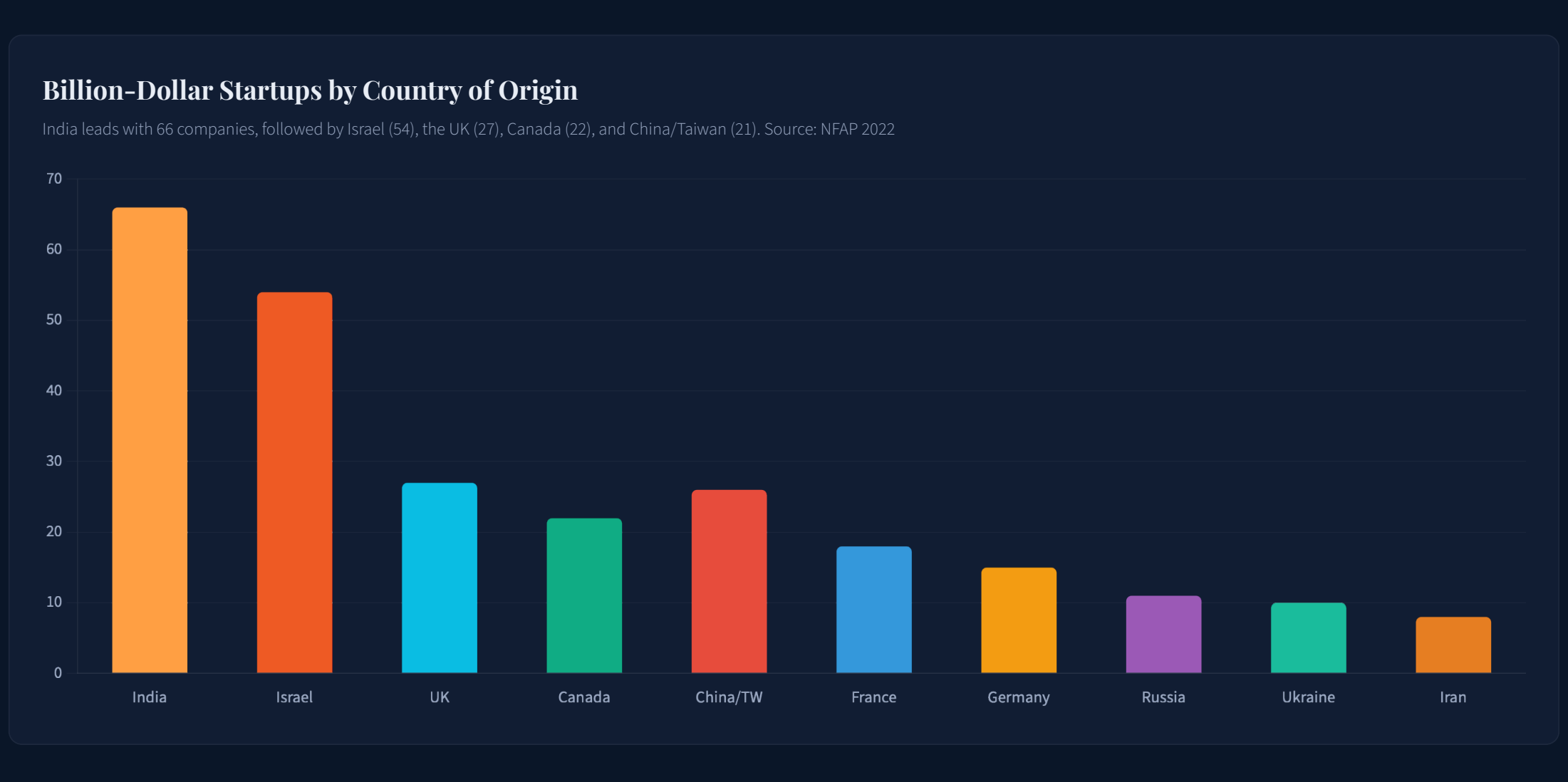
ACT III

Who, Where, and What

The immigrant founder ecosystem spans 65 countries, clusters in specific industries, and concentrates in a handful of U.S. innovation hubs.

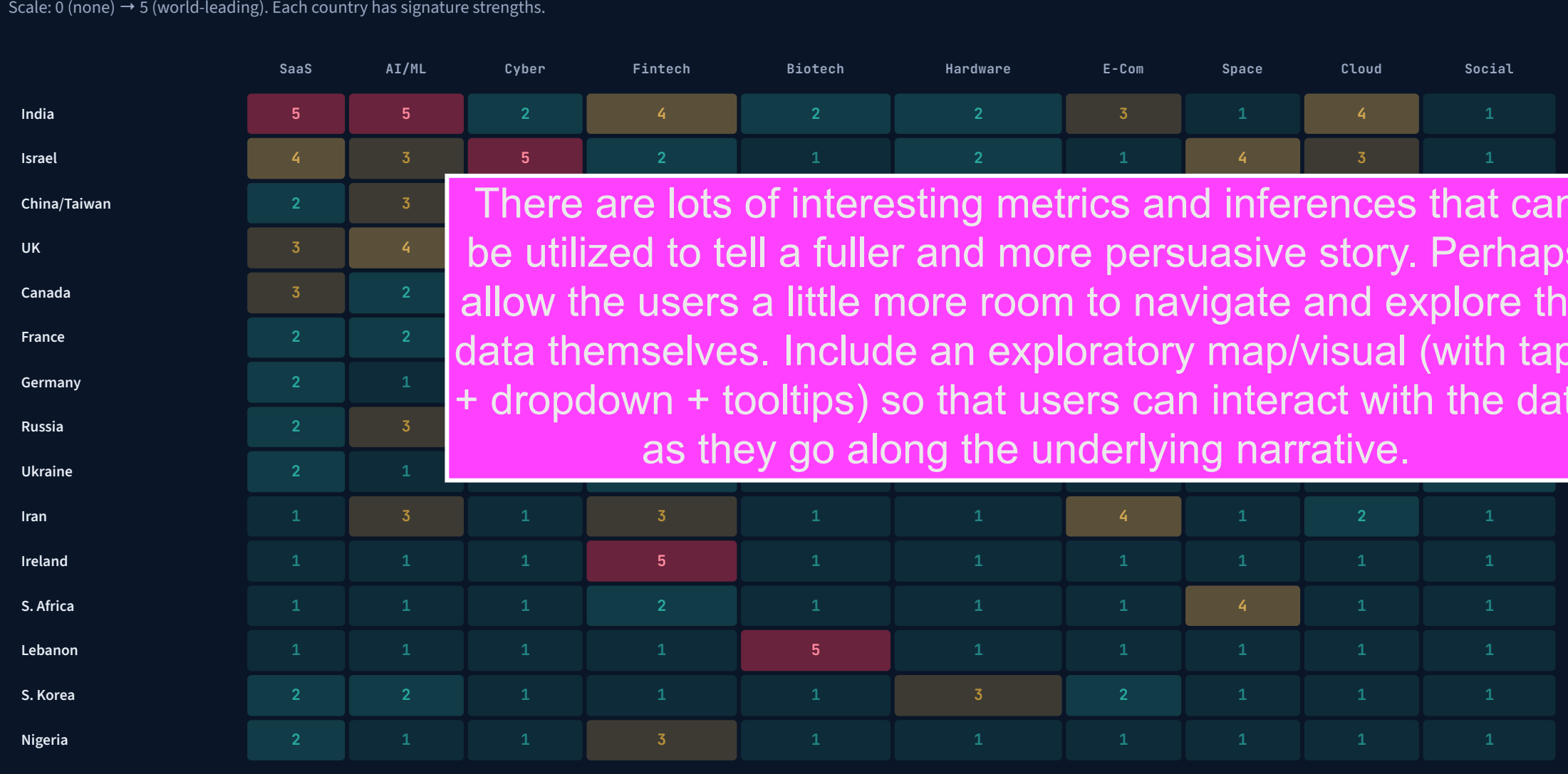
Billion-Dollar Startups by Country of Origin

India leads with 66 companies, followed by Israel (54), the UK (27), Canada (22), and China/Taiwan (21). Source: NFAP 2022



Country × Industry Concentration

Scale: 0 (none) → 5 (world-leading). Each country has signature strengths.

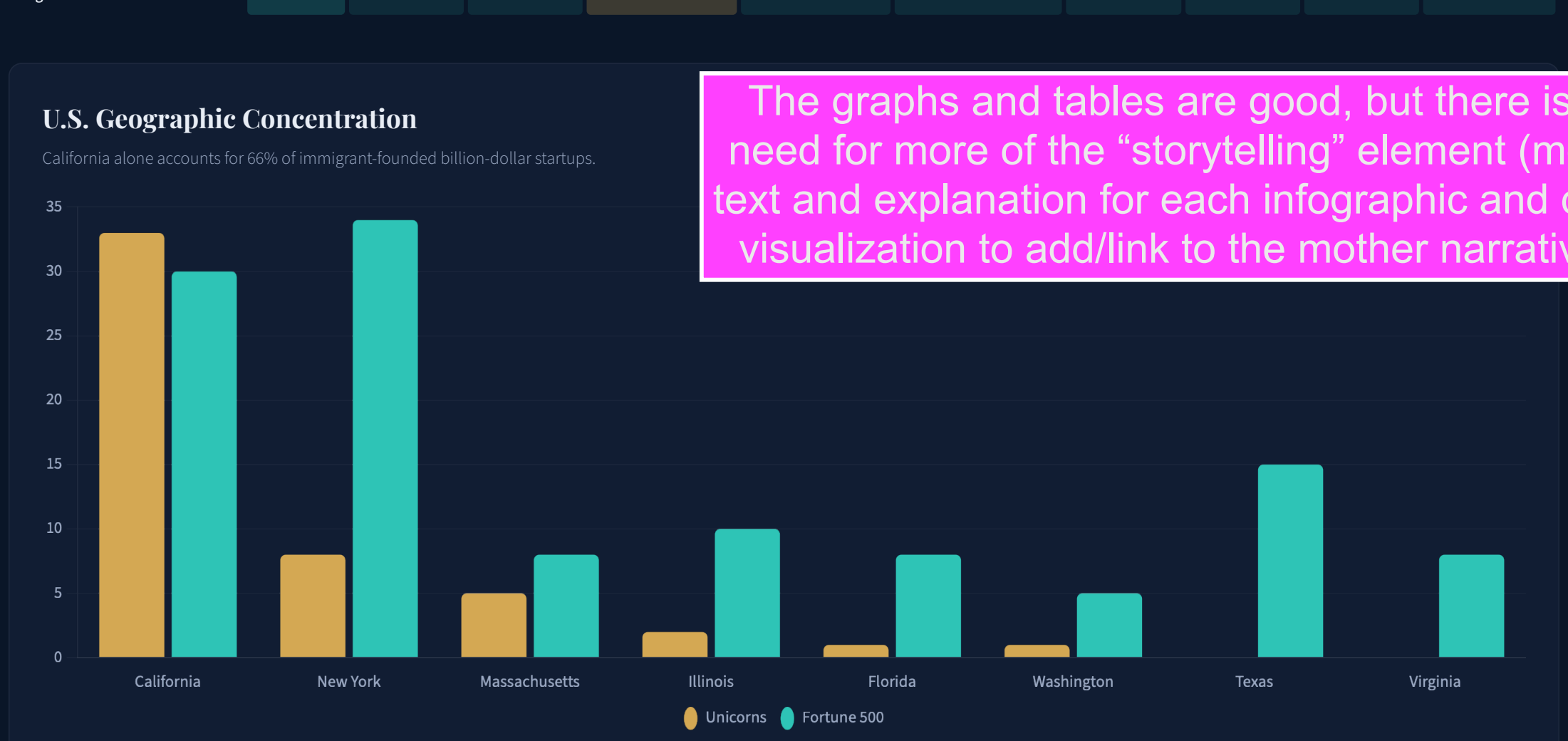


	SaaS	AI/ML	Cyber	Fintech	Biotech	Hardware	E-Com	Space	Cloud	Social
India	5	5	2	4	2	2	3	1	4	1
Israel	4	3	5	2	1	2	1	4	3	1
China/Taiwan	2	3	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]
UK	3	4	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]
Canada	3	2	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]
France	2	2	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]
Germany	2	1	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]
Russia	2	3	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]
Ukraine	2	1	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]	[illegible]
Iran	1	3	1	3	1	1	4	1	2	1
Ireland	1	1	1	5	1	1	1	1	1	1
S. Africa	1	1	1	2	1	1	1	4	1	1
Lebanon	1	1	1	1	5	1	1	1	1	1
S. Korea	2	2	1	1	1	3	2	1	1	1
Nigeria	2	1	1	3	1	1	1	1	1	1

There are lots of interesting metrics and inferences that can be utilized to tell a fuller and more persuasive story. Perhaps allow the users a little more room to navigate and explore the data themselves. Include an exploratory map/visual (with taps + dropdown + tooltips) so that users can interact with the data as they go along the underlying narrative.

U.S. Geographic Concentration

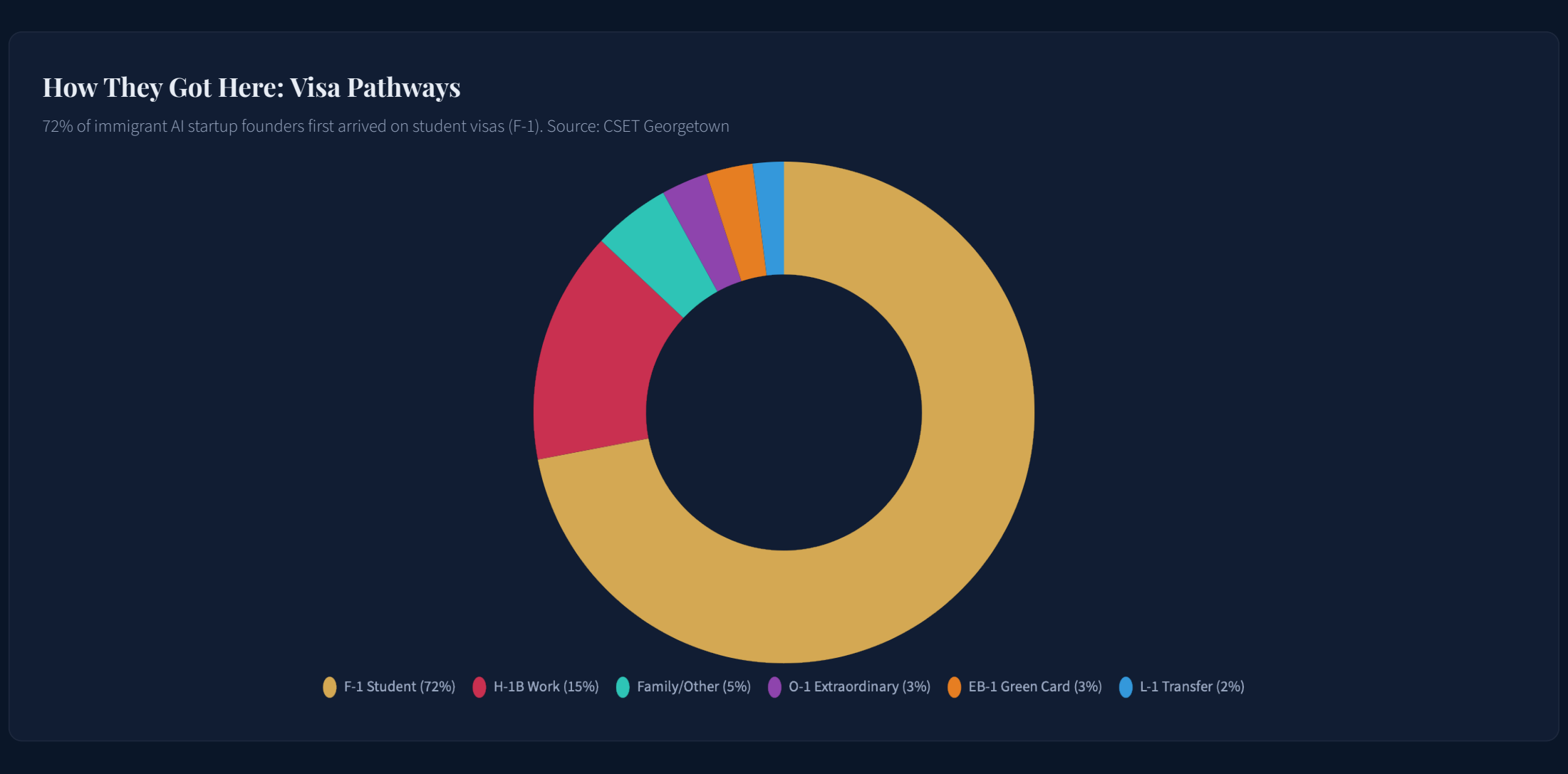
California alone accounts for 66% of immigrant-founded billion-dollar startups.



The graphs and tables are good, but there is a need for more of the “storytelling” element (more text and explanation for each infographic and data visualization to add/link to the mother narrative)

How They Got Here: Visa Pathways

72% of immigrant AI startup founders first arrived on student visas (F-1). Source: CSET Georgetown



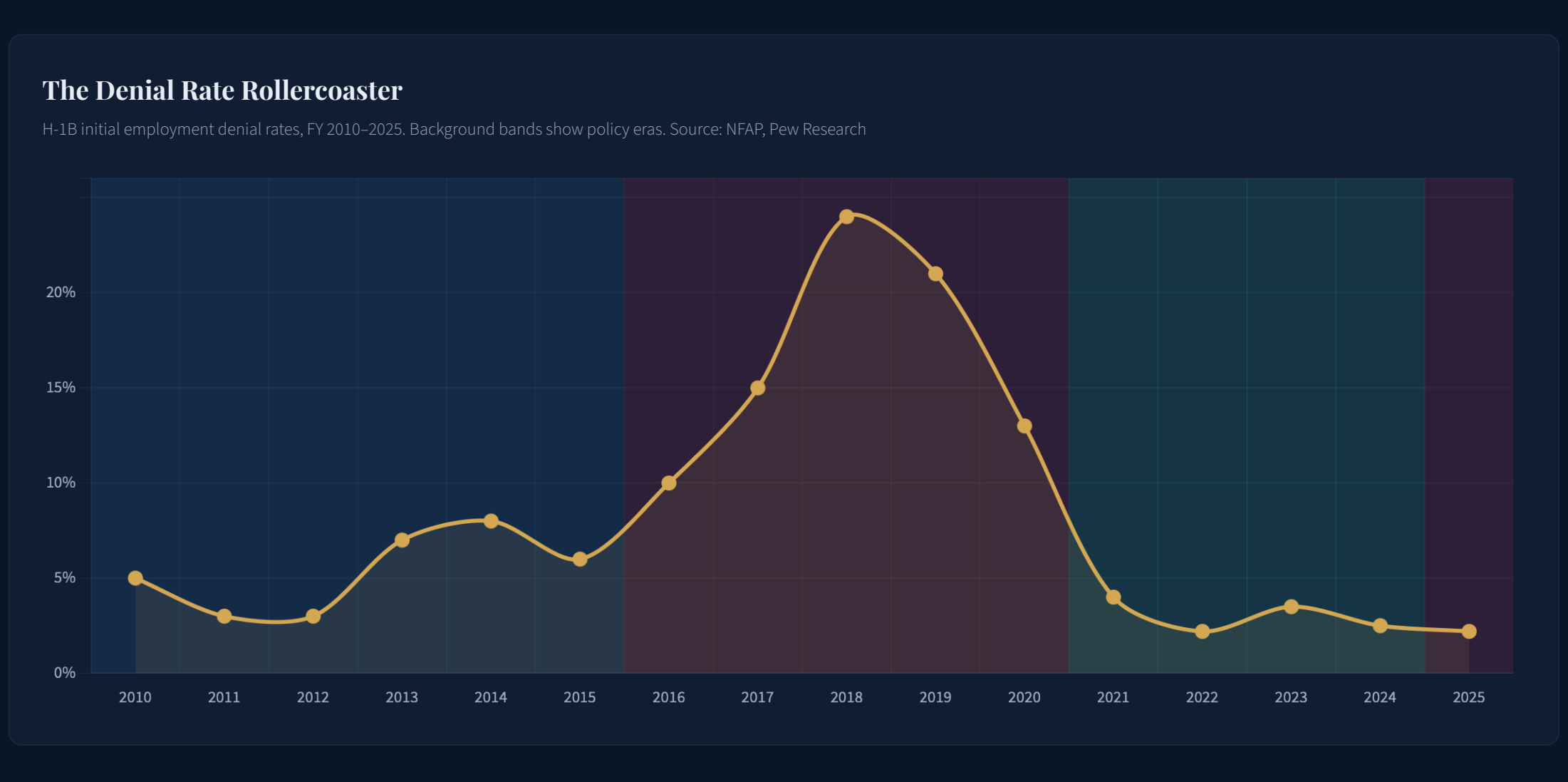
ACT IV

The Policy Reality

The walls are getting higher. H-1B denial rates have swung wildly with each administration, and new barriers — including a $100,000 application fee — threaten the pipeline.

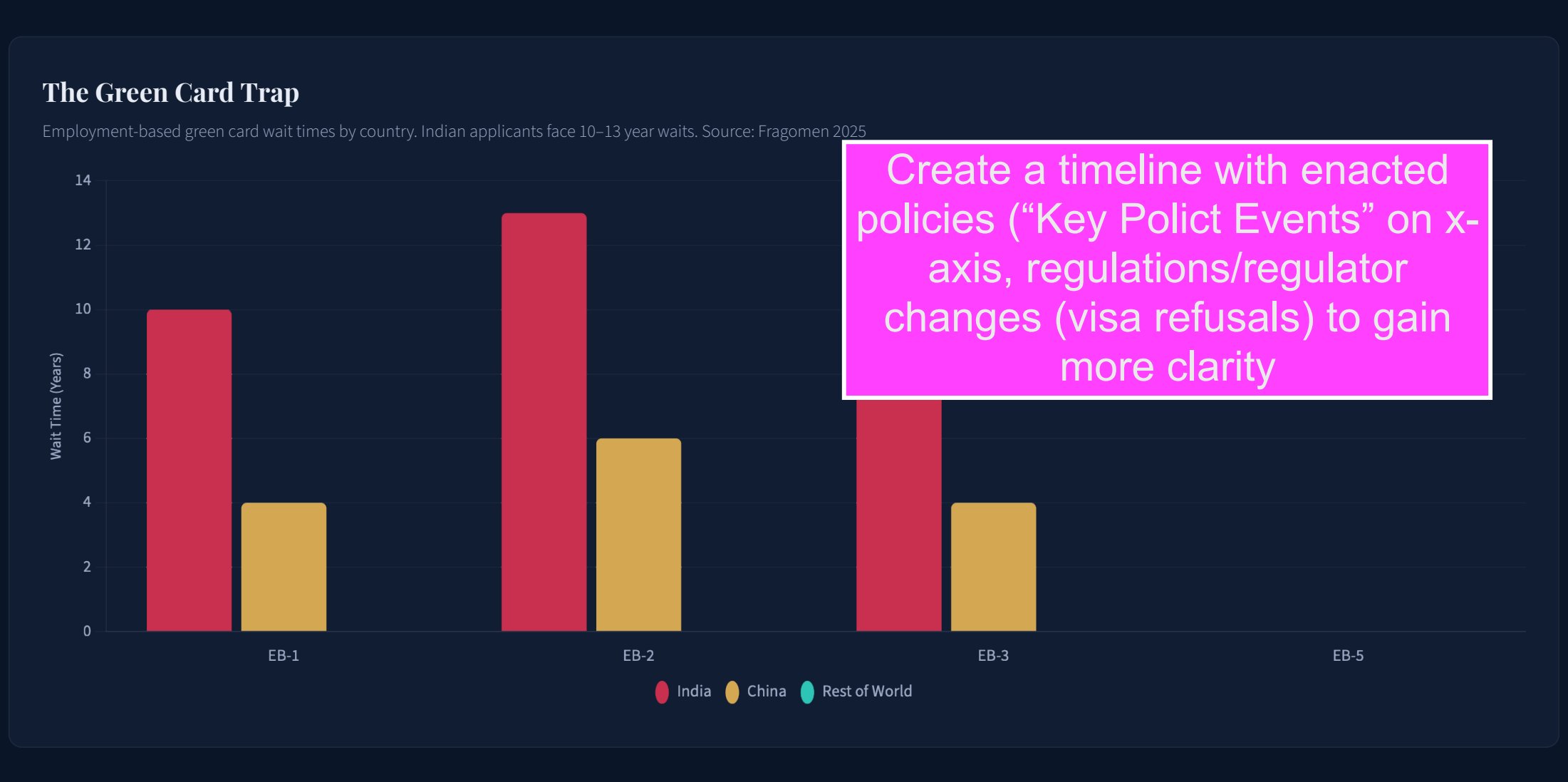
The Denial Rate Rollercoaster

H-1B initial employment denial rates, FY 2010–2025. Background bands show policy eras. Source: NFAP, Pew Research



The Green Card Trap

Employment-based green card wait times by country. Indian applicants face 10–13 year waits. Source: Fragomen 2025



Create a timeline with enacted policies (“Key Polict Events” on x-axis, regulations/regulator changes (visa refusals) to gain more clarity

Key Policy Events, 2012–2026

Green = expansive, Red = restrictive. Bold = critical impact.

Jun 2012 OBAMA **DACA announced — protects ~800K young immigrants**
Mar 2016 OBAMA STEM OPT extension expanded to 24 months
Jan 2017 TRUMP **Travel Ban 1.0 — 7 countries; 700+ detained**
Apr 2017 TRUMP **"Buy American, Hire American" Executive Order**
Sep 2017 TRUMP **Trump announces end of DACA**
Jun 2018 TRUMP **Supreme Court upholds travel ban**
Oct 2018 TRUMP **H-1B denial rate peaks at 24% (4× pre-Trump)**
Jun 2020 TRUMP **H-1B/L-1/J-1 entry suspended (COVID)**
Jan 2021 BIDEN Biden begins rescinding Trump orders
Mar 2021 BIDEN Biden rescinds "Buy American, Hire American"
Jan 2022 BIDEN 22 new STEM OPT fields added
Oct 2022 BIDEN H-1B denial rate drops to 2.2% (historic low)
Jan 2025 TRUMP **Trump 2nd term: border emergency, asylum block**
Sep 2025 TRUMP **$100,000 H-1B fee goes into effect**
Jan 2026 TRUMP **Visa processing paused for 75 countries**

The Brain Drain Is Real

Evidence of talent flight is mounting across every indicator.

82%
of employers lost foreign workers to visa issues

75%+
of U.S. scientists considering leaving

1.3M
Indians renounced citizenship (2015–2024)

+407%
growth in Canada Startup Visa approvals

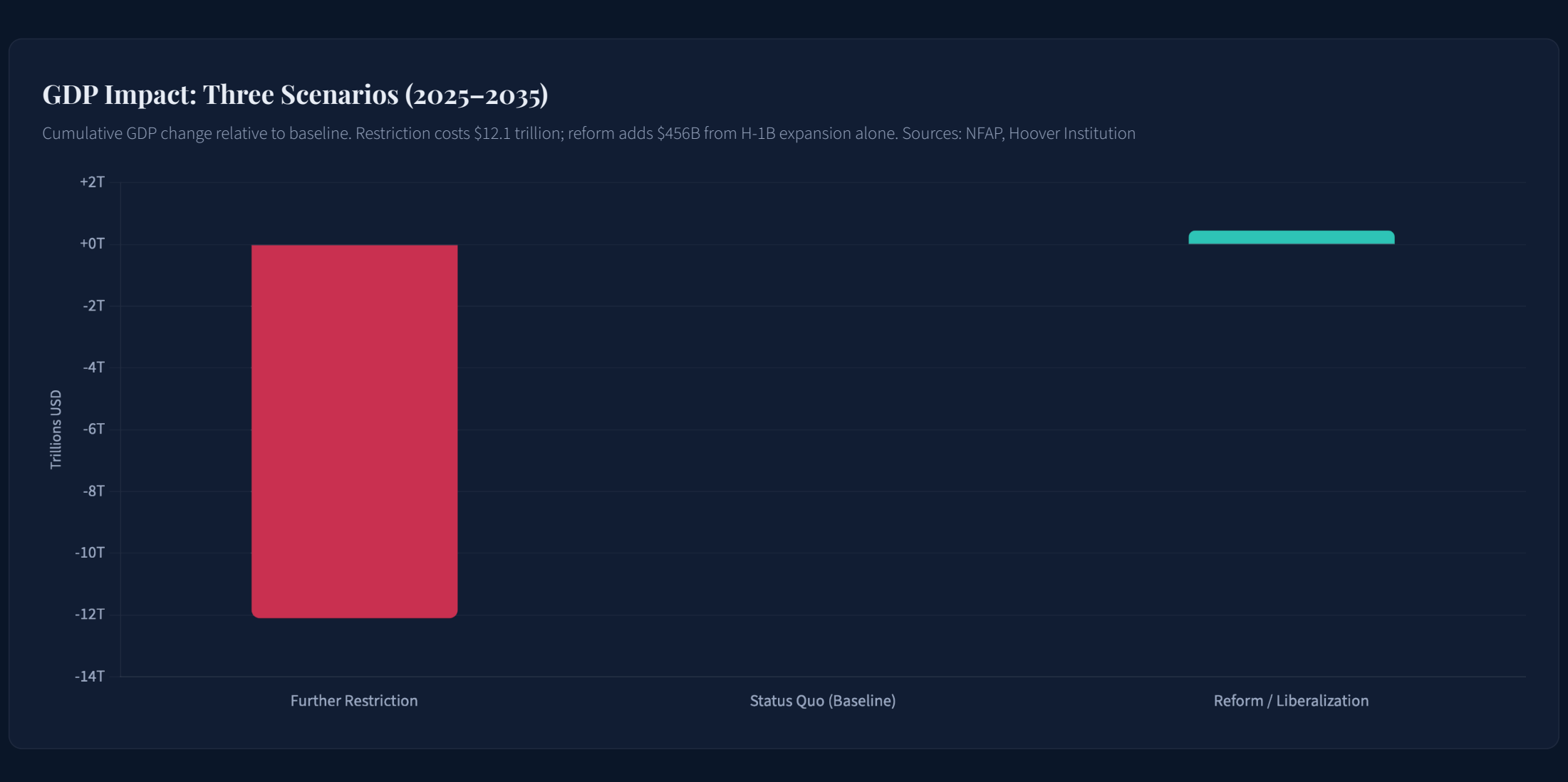
ACT V

So What?

The cost of restriction is not hypothetical. We can model it. And history has already shown us what happens when America closes its doors.

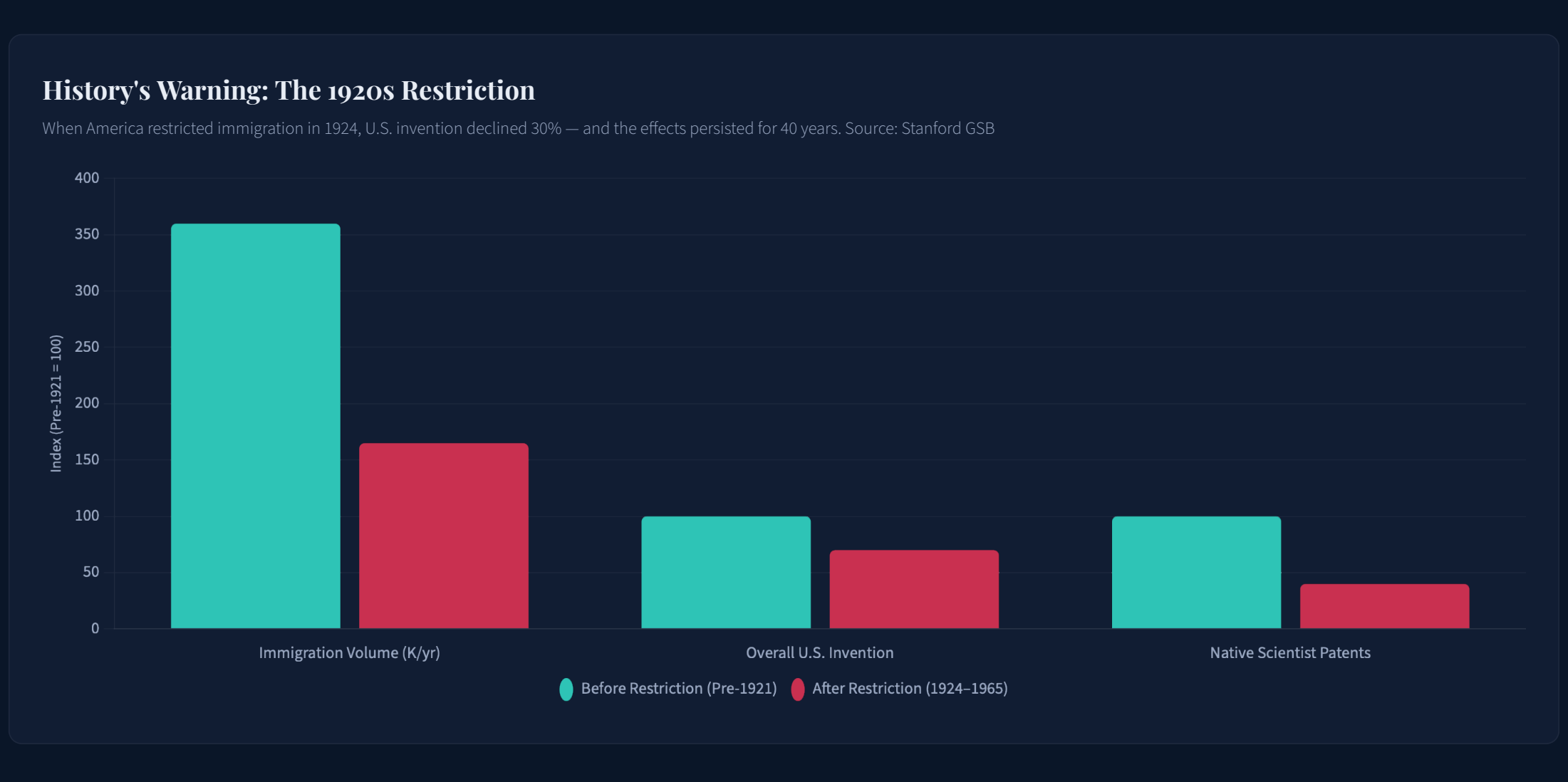
GDP Impact: Three Scenarios (2025–2035)

Cumulative GDP change relative to baseline. Restriction costs $12.1 trillion; reform adds $456B from H-1B expansion alone. Sources: NFAP, Hoover Institution



History's Warning: The 1920s Restriction

When America restricted immigration in 1924, U.S. invention declined 30% — and the effects persisted for 40 years. Source: Stanford GSB



Global Talent Competition

While the U.S. makes it harder, competitors roll out the red carpet.

COUNTRY	PROGRAM	PROCESSING	STARTUP VISA	RECRUITING US TALENT
United States	H-1B Lottery	6–18 months	No	—
Canada	Global Talent Stream	2 weeks	Yes	Yes
United Kingdom	Global Talent Visa	3–8 weeks	Yes	Yes
Germany	IT Specialist Visa	4–12 weeks	Limited	Yes
Singapore	Tech Pass	4–8 weeks	Yes	Yes

Questions of inclusion: (1) What kind of other metrics or qualitative data can we use to include any other foreign born immigrants?; (2) What about other non-tech (typical) immigrants?

Myths vs. Evidence

Common claims about immigration — tested against data.

CLAIM	VERDICT	KEY EVIDENCE
"H-1B workers displace Americans"	✗ Mostly False	No displacement found — Richmond Fed, 2025
"Restricting immigration creates jobs"	✗ False	Firms offshore 0.3–0.9 jobs per unfilled H-1B — NBER
"Immigrants are a fiscal burden"	✗ False	$14.5 trillion fiscal surplus since 1994 — Cato Institute
"We can innovate without immigrants"	✗ False	36% of U.S. patents involve immigrants; 30% decline in 1920s — Stanford/NBER
"H-1B workers suppress wages"	◐ Mixed	Firm-level effects exist, but economy-wide wages rise +1.7–2.6% — NBER

Check further if the information/evidence —> do they corroborate the narrative?

What's at Stake

The data is clear. Immigrant entrepreneurs are not a side note in the American innovation story — they are the story.

- Immigrant-founded companies employ **15.4 million** people and generate **$8.6 trillion** in revenue
- Continued restriction could cost **$12.1 trillion in GDP** and **15.7 million workers** over the next decade
- The 1920s showed that closing doors reduces innovation for **40 years**
- Canada, the UK, and others are actively recruiting the talent America turns away
- H-1B reform alone could generate **+$456B in GDP** and **+$113B in tax revenue**

Built by Immigrants, Threatened by Policy
Harvard University · Data Visualization Group Project · Spring 2025
Data sources: NFAP · American Immigration Council · NBER · Kauffman · Pew · Brookings · Hoover · Cato · CSET Georgetown